As the proceeding chapters will illustrate, individuals who do not belong to the dominant Sunni Islam (where fault lines are further drawn between the Deobandi and Barelvi schools) are often lower in the line of service delivery and protection offered by the state. The state–citizen relationship is not the same for all Pakistanis, where discrimination on the basis of religion has become part of the status quo.

So whither the social contract? The state–citizen relationship in Pakistan is constrained by problems of terrorism, sectarianism, provincialism, infrastructural inadequacies, in other words the state's struggle and often failure to provide physical, social, political and economic security and stability for its citizens. The more direct interference of the army in the past, and its crucial role in combating terrorism in present day Pakistan, not to mention its continued influence (if not control) over foreign affairs in the country and its access to a large chunk of the budget, has further strengthened the army. Therefore, any discussion about the state and democracy in Pakistan is incomplete without understanding the place of the Pakistani army. This is also reflected in the findings of this study.

Young Pakistanis may have doubts about the democratic system, may be ignorant or dismissive about their rights and responsibilities as citizens, and may lack confidence in state institutions, but they have complete faith in the functioning of the army. They are more confident in the army's ability to provide justice and security than they are in any other institution in the country. While the Pakistani state exists, it is largely irrelevant in the lives of ordinary Pakistanis, having been unable to provide any economic or social security and repeatedly accused of corruption and negligence. The social contract between the state and the citizens in Pakistan is therefore broken, not only because of the lack of responsibility on the part of the state, but also because of the citizens' lack of involvement in strengthening this relationship. While the NCEPG (2018) plans to fix this broken relationship, highlighting how 'better governance and service delivery through public inclusion and effectiveness of state institutions at district and tehsil level' is important 'to regain citizen trust and engagement with State' (NACTA 2018, p. 9), this realization may be a little too late, especially when that social contract is now about strengthening the relationship between the 'security state' and its citizens. The entry of the PTM in 2018 might present an opportunity for the state to show this commitment to fixing its broken relationship with its citizens. Among PTM's demands are basic rights as guaranteed under the constitution of Pakistan, including the rights of Pashtuns (and other ethnic minorities, evident in the support given to their grievances in the PTM rallies)